DEFENSIVE CYBERSECURITY EXERCISE

Operation Silent Ridge

A patrol's movement details may have leaked.

Your team finds out what happened — and proves it.



EVENT DAY BRIEFING · ALL CONTENT FICTIONAL · READ-ONLY INVESTIGATION

BEFORE WE START

Two things to learn in the next ten minutes

01

The story — what happened at 09:30 this morning

A fictional patrol is in the field and its movement details may have been disclosed. You are the incoming SOC shift. Everything you investigate is fictional, pre-collected, and safe to touch.

02

Your setup - registration, four tabs, three desktops

We walk through registration and every login, click by click, until your team has claimed its first ticket and answered its first question. No prior knowledge assumed.

WHEN WE'RE DONE

You will know the incident story, be logged into everything, and have points on the board. Then the exercise clock starts for real.

PART 1 · THE STORY

09:30 UTC: the outgoing shift hands you a problem

Patrol **LANTERN** is already in the field. The outgoing shift suspects its movement details were disclosed — an account password was reset at 09:20, and a viewer tool was run minutes later. Endpoint, network, identity, document-service and SIEM exports are already collected.

No confirmed harm. Do not assume it is over.

WHAT WE KNOW

- A password reset happened at 09:20 UTC
- A viewer tool was downloaded and accessed a browser session store
- All evidence exports are already collected and waiting for you

WHAT WE DON'T KNOW

- Which movements were exposed, and to whom
- How access was gained
- Which systems are still affected
- Whether the incident has ended

WHAT YOU DO ABOUT IT

- Investigate the evidence in teams
- Label every claim: confirmed, assessed, or unknown
- Build a defensible shared assessment before the day ends

All names, hosts, addresses and artifacts are fictional exercise material. Nothing here is a real system or person.

PART 1 · THE STORY

How the day works: claim, investigate, answer, share

1 - CLAIM

Pick open tickets in the IRIS queue. Up to three active lanes per team.

→

2 · INVESTIGATE

Use the desktop tools on the released evidence. Read-only, always.

→

3 - ANSWER

Submit the requested value in CTFd. Four points unassisted; one with Help 3.

→

4 - SHARE

The finding publishes to IRIS. Your team's closed tickets unlock its next phase.

WORTH KNOWING UP FRONT

Help 1 and 2 are free. Help 3 is the full walkthrough and permanently reduces that question from four points to one.

Wrong answers cost nothing. You only gain points. Try, read the next hint, and try again.

Stuck? Relinquish the ticket in IRIS to free one of your three lanes. Your solved questions and points remain.

No reports or approvals. Answering questions and sharing findings is the job.

Four browser tabs and three team desktops

TAB / APP	ADDRESS	WHAT IT'S FOR
IRIS - incident queue	iris.cyberexperts.org	Claim or relinquish tickets and read shared findings
CTFd - questions	ctfd.cyberexperts.org	Submit answers, use help, and watch the scoreboard
Wazuh - log search	wazuh.cyberexperts.org	Search historical SIEM records for the named time range
Three team desktops	guac.cyberexperts.org	Forensics A, Forensics B, Analysis: Autopsy, Wireshark, Cutter, files

THE ONE RULE THAT KEEPS THINGS FAST

Do all browsing in **your own laptop browser**. Inside the three desktops, use only the investigation tools. Opening browsers there consumes event capacity and adds lag.

1 Register your team, save the handout, open IRIS

DO THIS NOW

1. One captain opens **https://ctfd.cyberexperts.org/silent-ridge/register** and enters the enrollment code.

2. Bookmark the private retrieval page and use **Print / save handout**. It is the way back to every generated login.

3. Open **https://iris.cyberexperts.org**, log in with the team IRIS credentials, and confirm that the ticket queue opens.

HOW TO CHECK

You see a list of tickets with statuses such as **available**.

Registration pending? Keep the retrieval page open. It updates when all three desktops and accounts are ready.

IRIS is where your team claims work. CTFd questions appear only for tickets your team has activated.

2 Open CTFd in a second tab and log in as yourself

DO THIS NOW

1. Open a second tab: **https://ctfd.cyberexperts.org**

2. Log in with **your personal seat** login —

it looks like **team-04-p02** — and the seat password from the handout.

Each teammate uses their own seat.

3. You land on the question queue.

It may be nearly empty — questions appear here only for tickets your team owns.

4. Open the **Scoreboard** link.

All teams start at zero.

HOW TO CHECK

You can see the question queue and the scoreboard.

A 403 or "no permission" page means you used the team IRIS login here — switch to your seat login.

CTFd is where answers are checked and points are earned. Points belong to the team, no matter which seat submits.

3 Open your team's three desktop connections

DO THIS NOW

1. Third tab: **https://guac.cyberexperts.org**

2. Log in with the Guacamole credentials from the handout. You will see Forensics A, Forensics B, and Analysis. Use the handout's VNC password if a desktop asks.

3. Assign the three connections across your team. Each is an isolated Linux desktop. Evidence lives under **/evidence**.

HOW TO CHECK

You see a Linux desktop with icons for **Autopsy**, **Wireshark** and **Cutter**, and a file manager that opens **/evidence**.

Three desktops per team support three parallel work lanes. Everything under /evidence and /originals is mounted read-only.

4 Claim your first ticket, answer your first question

1. In the IRIS tab, find a ticket marked **available** and press **Claim ticket**. Your team now owns it.

2. Switch to the CTFd tab — the ticket's questions are visible. Open one; help levels 1 and 2 are free.

3. Investigate with the tool the question names (next page shows all five).

4. Type the requested value and press **Check answer**. Correct: four points and an IRIS finding. Level 3 is the full walkthrough; unlocking it costs 75%, leaving one point.

HOW TO CHECK

The scoreboard shows your team above zero, and the finding appears in IRIS within about ten seconds.

Finishing every question closes your team's copy. Complete all 20 tickets and 80 questions. Each team has its own progress and unlocks.

PART 2 · YOUR SETUP

Five tools, five jobs — the question always names its tool

TOOL	QUESTIONS	WHAT YOU DO WITH IT
Autopsy	32 of 80	Open the prepared case on the desktop; browse files, search keywords, inspect the artifacts the question points at
Wazuh	24 of 80	In your own browser (wazuh.cyberexperts.org): Discover, open the historical data view, set the UTC range in the question, then filter one step at a time
Wireshark	8 of 80	Open the capture under /evidence/network; apply the display filter the question suggests (e.g. udp.port == 514)
Cutter	8 of 80	Static analysis only — open the training binary, read strings and named functions; never debug or run it
File manager	8 of 80	Walk the /evidence tree and read files directly — the simplest tool, try it first when unsure

IF A TOOL FEELS FOREIGN

Help levels 1 and 2 are free. If you still need it, unlock level 3 for a complete walkthrough; it costs 75% of that question's points so your team can keep moving.

GROUND RULES

Rules of engagement: four yes, four no

YES — DO

· **Use UTC** for evidence times and elapsed minutes for exercise deadlines

· **Label every claim** confirmed, assessed (with confidence), or unknown

· **Cite the evidence** — file, host, timestamp — behind every answer

· **Share and ask** — findings are shared by design; read other teams' completed findings to see the wider incident

NO — DON'T

· **Never execute evidence** — no running binaries, scripts or documents found in the material

· **Never scan or contact** external systems, and never direct real personnel "in the field"

· **Don't invent harm**, adversary names, or movements the evidence doesn't show

· **Don't browse inside the desktop** — keep it fast for your team's tools

Every address, identity and artifact in this exercise is fictional. The defensive habits above are the real takeaway — they are what makes an assessment defensible.

WHEN THINGS GO WRONG

If something breaks: what to try before raising a hand

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
“Connection interrupted” on the question page	Wait a few seconds and retry — accepted answers are retained; nothing you earned is lost
Points or findings not showing yet	Give it about ten seconds — scoring and findings synchronize in the background
Desktop frozen or disconnected	Reconnect from the Guacamole tab. Choose the same named connection and your workspace will still be there.
Login refused everywhere	Check you're on the right app with the right login kind (team vs seat vs Guacamole), then ask a facilitator

STILL STUCK

Raise a hand. Facilitators can pause the clock, retry provisioning, rotate a lost private retrieval link, or recover a stuck ticket.

YOU'RE READY

Success today looks like this

- A **defensible shared assessment** of what happened to LANTERN — every claim labeled and cited
- **Timely updates** — brief even when confidence is low
- **Proportionate recommendations** — no invented harm, no guesswork presented as fact
- Points on the board are the byproduct, not the goal

YOUR FOUR ADDRESSES

iris.cyberexperts.org | ctfd.cyberexperts.org | wazuh.cyberexperts.org | guac.cyberexperts.org

All in your own browser. All fictional. Good hunting.